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Short: Are you a koala 🐨 or a duck 🦆?

You gotta choose!

JOS VISSER
NOV 12, 2025

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> *This article is the first in a series of Wednesday Wisdom "Shorts". What are shorts? In short: It is a Wednesday Wisdom article that is shorter than usual. Why shorts? Well, sometimes the topic that I want to write about really does not require an expansive article with examples and anecdotes. Sometimes short is just beautiful.*

Today, I am asking you to take a good look at yourself and answer the following timeless question: Are you a koala or are you a duck? But, before we get there, let's first discuss another timeless question: What is the best programming language?

This is a question that gets a lot of traction on LinkedIn, which is in itself already proof that it is a dumb question. But, regardless of that insight, I am always really, really, surprised that people can profess undying support for one particular language over all others; it is a level of conviction that I completely lack. It is not just that I am pragmatic and accept that different environments use different programming languages and therefore I need to speak all of them. I really cannot commit to a single language for every purpose. I just don't have it in me.

This lack of commitment to a single thing is visible in other parts of my life as well, obviously with the exception of my dedication to my daughter and to Mrs. Wednesday Wisdom 😇. I am a person that does something very intensely for a while and then I move on and do something else intensely for a while. I used to be an active SCUBA diver, did that for years, and then it sort of evaporated and now I am flying planes a lot. I go through bouts of gaming, piano playing, and athletics. When I play video games, I buy a few games, play them for a while, but I rarely finish any of them.

> Seriously, who has the time for that anyway?

Many years ago I got my "sports masseur" diploma and now I am working on getting my California boating license and my ham radio technician license. For years I posted a music album recommendation on Facebook every night and then I stopped. I drove motorcycles for years, stopped, started again, and then stopped again. It is a sort of ADHD or ADD, but at a much higher level.

The same happens in my work. In the last few decades, I coded professionally in C++, Java, Go, and Python. I used Bigtable, Spanner, MySQL, Postgres, and DynamoDB. My messages were sent with MQ Series, Kafka, and SQS. I edited my code with vim, Atom, VSCode, and IntelliJ. My software ran on self-managed servers, but also on Borg, Tupperware, GCP, Azure, and AWS.

The upside of all of this is that I can do many things. The downside is that I never get really good at anything. True mastery of any topic requires thousands of hours of consistently applying yourself to a single topic and I usually don't get there. In most of my endeavors I reach a fairly decent level (except in piano playing and video gaming, at which I both still suck), and then I stop and go do something else for a while. The end result is that I can do lots of different things very well, but I am not great at any of them. In other words, I am a duck!

Ducks can swim, fly, and walk, but none of it very well. Fish are definitely better swimmers, most birds are better fliers, and most land animals are obviously better walkers or runners. A duck is not the best at any of them, but it *can* do all three of them!

Compare this to the koala. Koala's cannot do much, but they are *awesome* at the few things that they can do. For instance, a koala can hang motionless for hours, its muscles relaxed yet ready to shift its weight with effortless control. Where other creatures will slip or strain, the koala simply holds on. The koala is supremely adapted to the Eucalyptus trees it lives in and which leaves it eats. It has a specialized liver that detoxifies the poisons in the leaves; its intestines are optimized to house the bacteria to break down the leaves' fibrous material. It also has a highly selective palate: A koala can distinguish between hundreds of Eucalyptus species but will eat only a few dozen, and only the freshest, least toxic leaves. In other words, a koala can only do a small number of things, but it is very, very good at them

> Thank you ChatGPT for summarizing the wonderful specialization of the koala.

Put a koala anywhere else and it will die. Ducks on the other hand are found on every continent (except Antarctica).

I regularly see job ads that look phenomenally fun and interesting, but that require many years of in-depth experience with some technology. I am typically convinced that I can do the job, but when I send my resume, it reads like the resume of a duck: Lots of good experience with lots of different things. Typically, I do not qualify for these jobs, which is kinda sad. But, being a duck, I can usually go everywhere and thrive, which softens the blow a bit.

I had no choice but to be a duck, it is in my nature and it shows in both my professional and my personal life. It is important to know yourself well though, so that you can play to your strengths.

So, my question to you: Are you a duck or are you a koala?

Here is the good news: Regardless of whether you are a koala or a duck, you can still subscribe to Wednesday Wisdom and profit from it.

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Badr El Mazaz 12 Nov
Liked by Jos Visser
I am definitely a duck but maybe the sweet spot is being a duck by nature but a koala in a few areas, that T-shaped (or even M-shaped) balance between breadth and depth.
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Jos Visser 12 Nov
Author
Interesting thought....!
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Donal 12 Nov
Liked by Jos Visser
Do you get to choose? I'm 100% a duck but I have a lot of time for koalas... ✨
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Jos Visser 12 Nov
Author
There is room in the world for both. I appreciate koalas a lot.
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Flare 12 Nov
not a koala not a duck I am a DRAGON
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Johnxc 12 Nov
So, what kind of games you play?
LIKE REPLY (1) SHARE

Jos Visser 12 Nov
Author
A wide range. Currently I am slogging through Hollow Knight (the original), though it is a bit too hard for my taste. Outer Worlds. Halo. Lots of Indie games.
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